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INFRASTRUCTURE

SHAPING THE NEXT TOURISM POWERHOUSE

With rich cultural heritage and natural beauty, India can become a global tourism favourite. But sustainability should be at the heart of all such efforts

As India celebrates its 78th Independence Day, it's an opportune moment to reflect on the transformative potential of our tourism sector. Tourism is one of the largest employers in the services sector, and given its tertiary impact, the industry can be a game-changer for India. With its rich cultural heritage, stunning landscapes, and warm and hospitable people, India has all the makings of a global tourism powerhouse. The country has also significantly enhanced its stature as a global destination for business opportunities. This has helped the country claim an increasingly prominent place on the world travel and tourism map. Yet, India is currently only the 22nd most visited nation in the world. Our goal should be to climb into the top 10 within the next 20-25 years.

The domestic travel and tourism industry has evolved and witnessed multifold growth, fuelled by improvements in infrastructure, rising earnings of the Indian middle and upper middle classes, and an increasing desire to spend more on travel. While international tourism is touching pre-Covid levels, domestic leisure tourism has surpassed pre-pandemic numbers, reflecting the critical strength of our domestic tourism market. The industry has



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